Lesson 08: The Paragraph 1: Format, Parts, Title and Topic Sentence

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph (sections I-VI); Appendix B Capitalization.

In this lesson

You will learn what a paragraph is, how to format it, and what its parts are, using the model paragraph "Missing My Childhood Days". Then you will study the title, with the rules for capital letters, and the topic sentence. Lesson 11 continues with supporting sentences, transitions and concluding sentences.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Define a paragraph and format one correctly.
- Identify the parts of a paragraph in a model text.
- Write titles that follow the capitalization and punctuation rules.
- Find the topic, the controlling idea and the predictors in a topic sentence.
- Write good topic sentences and correct weak ones.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
paragraph	a group of sentences about one main idea	Paragraph writing is the foundation for all types of academic writing.
double spaced	with one empty line between the lines of text	Type or write double spaced.
title	a short name that shows the topic and catches the readers' interest	The Best Invention
topic sentence	the sentence that contains the main idea, usually the first one	I enjoy three aspects of my writing class.
topic	what the paragraph is about	my high school life
controlling idea	your attitude or opinion about the topic	miss for three reasons
predictors	the points you are going to explain in the body of the paragraph	friends, sports, and time for myself

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
foun·DA·tion	basis, groundwork of something more complicated	A paragraph is the foundation for essays and research papers.
im·PLY	say indirectly	A title usually states or implies the topic.

Rules and explanations

What is a paragraph?

A paragraph is a group of sentences about one main idea. It tells the readers what you think of a topic (your main idea) and why (your supporting ideas).

Paragraph format

- Center the title in the middle of the top line.
- Indent the first line (start with a few open spaces).
- Type or write double spaced.
- Each sentence follows the one before it. Do not start a new line for each sentence.
- Use font size 12 if you type.

The parts of a paragraph

The book colour codes the parts. In "Missing My Childhood Days": | Part | Its job | Colour | In the model | |---|---|---|---| | Title | shows the topic and catches interest | pink | Missing My Childhood Days | | Topic sentence | shows the main idea | red | Thanks to two people and one place, my childhood was filled with fun. | | Supporting sentences | explain the main idea | green | The first special person was my cousin Hector. (+ two more) | | Supporting details | explain the supporting sentences; the longest part | blue | I was the only child to my mom … | | Transitions | connect the ideas and guide the readers | yellow | first, Secondly, Lastly | | Concluding sentence(s) | finish the paragraph | red | Nowadays I do not have Hector and Lisandra in my life … priceless memories. |

Colour coding shows you that no part is missing, that the parts are in the right order, and that the details (blue) are the longest part.

The hamburger way. Sesame seeds = title; top bun = topic sentence; the middle = supporting sentences with details (more ingredients, more taste); sauces that hold it together = transitions; bottom bun = concluding sentence (the same bread in a different shape: it restates the topic sentence in a different way).

Titles

1. A good title is short: often one word or a phrase, usually not a complete sentence: *The Best Invention; The Characteristics of a Good Boss*.
2. It catches the readers' interest but does not tell everything: *A Long-Kept Secret; To Mask or Not to Mask*.
3. It follows the capitalization and punctuation rules:

- Capitalize the first word and all major words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs and pronouns).
- Do not capitalize articles (a, an, the), short prepositions (in, on, from…), coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or…) or "to" before a verb, unless it is the first word: *The Story of Our Mother and the Little Cat; Five Interesting Ways to Make a Living*.
- Never capitalize the entire title. No period at the end, no quotation marks, no underlining.

Wrong	Correct
the day I arrived in Chicago	The Day I Arrived in Chicago
THE MAKING OF A DOCTOR	The Making of a Doctor
A Very Frustrating Experience.	A Very Frustrating Experience
"Advice from My Mother"	Advice from My Mother
The Mysterious Noise (underlined)	The Mysterious Noise

Capital letters in sentences (Appendix B)

Capitalize (but never write a whole text in capitals):

1. the first word of a sentence;
2. the pronoun "I";
3. continents, countries, nationalities, ethnicities and languages: *Asia, Egypt, Egyptian, Arabic*;
4. months and days of the week: *August, Monday* (but not seasons: *the fall semester*);
5. proper nouns, the specific names of people, places, colleges, religions, holidays, courses… (each word except prepositions, articles, coordinating conjunctions and "to"): *Harper College, Islam, Museum of Science and Industry*. Common nouns (general names) are not capitalized: *religions* but *Christianity*.

The topic sentence

The topic sentence contains the main idea and usually comes first. It has two essential parts and one optional part:

- the **topic** of your paragraph;
- the **controlling idea**: your attitude or opinion about the topic;
- (optional but preferred) **predictors**: the points you are going to explain.

I miss my high school life for three reasons: friends, sports, and time for myself. → topic: my high school life; controlling idea: miss for three reasons; predictors: friends, sports, time for myself.

Five rules | Rule | Wrong | Right | |---|---|---| | 1. A complete sentence, with a subject and a verb | My interesting writing class | My writing class is interesting for three reasons. | | 2. A statement, not a question (if you ask a question, the answer in the next sentence is the topic sentence) | Why is learning English important? | Why is learning English important? It is so because good English skills benefit people in their study, work, and daily life. | | 3. Narrow down the topic | Year 2020 was a difficult year for me. | The COVID pandemic in Year 2020 made it difficult for me to study. | | 4. No announcement

| In this paragraph, I am going to talk about the disadvantages to online learning. | There are three disadvantages to online learning. | | 5. Not a fact (a fact has no controlling idea) | My classmates come from twelve different countries. | Representing twelve countries, my classmates are great resources for learning different cultures. |

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no capital letters, so capitalization needs extra attention: names of people and places, nationalities, languages, days, months, the pronoun "I", and the major words in a title ("arabic" → "Arabic", "my life in cairo" → "My Life in Cairo").

Practice

Exercise 1. Parts of a paragraph. Read "Difficulties in English Writing" (section IV). Mark the parts with colours or labels: title (pink), topic sentence (red), supporting sentences (green), supporting details (blue), concluding sentence (red), transitions (yellow).

Exercise 2. Titles. Do these titles follow the rules? Write the correct title. Example: From my home to school → From My Home to School.

1. the best ESL program
2. A SURPRISE VACATION
3. The Most Important Person In my life.
4. our writing classroom
5. My Most Important Day (in the book this title is underlined)
6. "The Best High School Math Teacher"

Exercise 3. Topic, controlling idea, predictors. Find the parts of each topic sentence (not all have predictors).

1. Writing is the most difficult skill to learn in English because I am not familiar with the writing style, it is hard to have new ideas, and the sentence structure is challenging to me.
2. Writing good paragraphs is easy if you follow these steps.
3. International students at Harper College prepare for life in the U.S. in several ways: academic study, social life, and community service.
4. My college cafeteria is very different from what I imagined.
5. Nuclear power is our greatest hope for solving the energy crisis.
6. Nuclear power is the greatest threat to life on the planet.
7. I do not like television commercials for three reasons.
8. Television commercials are insulting to women through the products, the images, and the language.

Exercise 4. Good topic sentences? Write True (good) or False. If False, say why and correct it. Example: *Electric cars* (False: not a complete sentence, no controlling idea) → I like electric cars more than gas-powered cars. (In the lesson material, items 7-10 are numbered 9, 7, 8, 9 by mistake.)

1. Electric cars are becoming more popular among young people.
2. A Tesla is an electric car.
3. I am going to write about my first exciting trip to Florida in my Tesla.
4. Are seat belts necessary?
5. Seat belts do not always save lives.
6. The benefits of owning a car: it is convenient, it saves time, and it provides freedom.
7. A college degree is good.
8. Full-time college students should not have a full-time job because it is not good for their physical, mental, and social life.
9. Is too hard to focus on study in an online class.
10. In this paragraph I will compare working on campus and working off campus.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me six titles with capitalization or punctuation mistakes. I will correct them and name the rule."
- "Here are three topic sentences for my psychology course: [paste]. For each one, name the topic, the controlling idea and the predictors, and check it against the five rules."
- "Ask me about my most unforgettable childhood memories. Then help me turn my answer into a topic sentence with predictors."

Writing task

A paragraph about your childhood (Warm-Up topic). Answer the Warm-Up question "What are your most unforgettable childhood memories? Why are they unforgettable?" in one paragraph of about 150 to 200 words. Use "Missing My Childhood Days" as your model. Include a centered title, a topic sentence with predictors, three supporting sentences with details and transitions (first, secondly, lastly), and a concluding sentence. Use the paragraph format.

Keep this paragraph: in Lesson 11 you will check it for unity, transitions and the concluding sentence.

Self-editing checklist

- Is my title short and correctly capitalized, with no period, quotation marks or underlining?
- Is my topic sentence a complete statement, narrow, and not a question, an announcement or a fact?
- Can I name its topic, controlling idea and predictors?
- Do my supporting sentences explain the predictors in the same order, with the details as the longest part?
- Did I capitalize names, places, nationalities, languages, days, months and "I"?
- Is the paragraph indented and double spaced, without a new line for each sentence?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

- Title: Difficulties in English Writing
- Topic sentence: For me, writing is one of the most difficult skills to learn in English.
- Supporting sentences: (1) First, with writing comes spelling. (2) Another challenge I face in English is sentence structure. (3) Finally, grammar is challenging.
- Supporting details: all the other sentences between the supporting sentences, from "Many words are pronounced the same" to "lead to errors in verbs."
- Transitions between the supporting ideas: First, Another, Finally. (Other connecting words inside the details: like, such as, because, Unfortunately, For example, At first, but, In contrast.)
- Concluding sentence: Despite all these difficulties in spelling, sentence structure, and grammar, writing remains to be one of my favorite aspects of learning.

Exercise 2 (book)

1. The Best ESL Program 2. A Surprise Vacation 3. The Most Important Person in My Life 4. Our Writing Classroom 5. My Most Important Day (not underlined) 6. The Best High School Math Teacher

Exercise 3 (book; spelling mistakes in the book's key are corrected)

1. Topic: writing. Controlling idea: the most difficult skill to learn in English. Predictors: I am not familiar with the writing style; it is hard to have new ideas; the sentence structure is challenging to me.
2. Topic: writing good paragraphs. Controlling idea: easy if you follow these steps.
3. Topic: international students at Harper College. Controlling idea: prepare for life in the U.S. in several ways. Predictors: academic study; social life; community service.
4. Topic: my college cafeteria. Controlling idea: very different from what I imagined.
5. Topic: nuclear power. Controlling idea: our greatest hope for solving the energy crisis.
6. Topic: nuclear power. Controlling idea: the greatest threat to life on the planet.
7. Topic: television commercials. Controlling idea: I do not like … for three reasons.
8. Topic: television commercials. Controlling idea: insulting to women. Predictors: the products; the images; the language.

Exercise 4 (book; the reasons and corrections are from the book's online feedback)

1. True
2. False: it is a fact; the controlling idea is missing. Correction: Tesla is the most popular electric car for business professionals.
3. False: it is an announcement. Correction: My first trip to Florida in my Tesla was very exciting.
4. False: it is a question. Correction: Seat belts are necessary for three reasons.
5. True

6. False: it is not a complete sentence; the main verb is missing. Correction: There are three benefits of owning a car: it is convenient, it saves time, and it provides freedom.
7. False: it is too broad. Correction: A college degree in business makes job search much easier.
8. True
9. False: it is not a complete sentence; the subject is missing. Correction: It is too hard to focus on study in an online class.
10. False: it is an announcement. Correction: Working on campus provides more advantages than working off campus.

My notes